in UP—Kalyan Singh, between 1991-92 and 1997–1999)[4]—the recent shift is much more expansive and far-reaching. K.N. Govindacharya, then general secretary of the party, argued in 1993 that the party would have to change the 'chaal, charitra aur chehra (working style, character and face)'[5] of its leadership to bring in aspirational and newly assertive castes and classes if it wanted to start winning. Nearly three decades on, this is substantially if not wholly the case in most of UP, and at the heart of the BJP's resurgence.

Two, the BJP built a grassroots party structure around most of the 1,47,164 voting booths in UP.[6] Chapter 4 shows that this new party cadre was deployed not just to get voters out to booths during election cycles but also, significantly, for targeted grassroots mobilisation around government welfare programmes—such as free housing, LPG gas connections and direct benefit cash transfers to farmers—outside of election campaigns. While all parties spend money on welfare programmes, this kind of precision-targeted political mobilisation around government lists of welfare beneficiaries in villages is new to north India. It has been done before more in southern states, notably in Tamil Nadu, which also has cadre-based parties like the All India Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK).

Three, the BJP refocused on an unapologetic Hindutva messaging, going back to its core ideology. As UP Deputy Chief Minister Dinesh Sharma told me in his office in Lucknow's Vidhan Sabha premises, 'The core reason for the BJP's victory is that we did not change our core principles. When we lost, we still remained strong on our ideals, as we did when we won. People's belief in us grew because we didn't do the politics of gain and loss.'[7] Chapter 5 examines at length what this means for Muslims, who constitute 19.2 per cent of UP's population (14.2 per cent nationwide).[8] While this was a key driver of the BJP's growth, it is also important to acknowledge that a focus on Hindutva as a cultural force alone could never, by itself, have delivered the massive Hindi heartland vote shares and mandates that the party has won since 2013.